

Parallel Structure (Parallelism)

Balanced sentences for Section A

Study guide for the University of Ibadan Postgraduate Test of English (EPT)

Parallelism is the principle that items joined in a series, a pair or a comparison should have the **same grammatical form**: nouns with nouns, verbs with verbs, *-ing* forms with *-ing* forms, and clauses with clauses. Parallel sentences are easier to read and sound more polished.

✓ The lady likes reading, cooking and swimming.

✗ The lady likes reading, to cook and swimming.

Where parallelism matters

1 Lists joined by and, or, but (coordinating conjunctions)

Remember them as **FANBOYS**: *for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so*.

✓ We need to buy yams, tomatoes and peppers.

✗ Every night she reads a book, singing a song and says a prayer.

✓ Every night she reads a book, sings a song and says a prayer.

2 Pairs joined by correlative conjunctions

both ... and, either ... or, neither ... nor, not only ... but also, whether ... or. Whatever follows the first word must match what follows the second.

✗ Getting a degree is neither cheap nor will it be easy.

✓ Getting a degree is neither cheap nor easy.

✗ He is not only a politician skilfully, but also an able artist.

✓ He is not only a skilful politician but also an able artist.

3 Comparisons with than and as ... as

✓ I would rather take the train than take the bus.

✓ Saying is one thing; doing is another.

✗ Saying is one thing; to do it is another.

4 Verbs in a series share the same tense and form

✓ He closed the door, opened the windows and sat down.

✗ He closed the door, was opening the windows and sat down.

5 Adverbs and adjectives stay in the same class

✓ She swam swiftly and gracefully.

✗ She swam with swiftness and gracefully.

✓ The report should be precise and original.

6 Repeated introductory words

If you repeat a word such as *to*, *that*, *how to* or *the*, repeat it for every item or for none.

✓ She taught me how to read, how to write and how to count.

✓ She taught me how to read, write and count.

✗ She taught me how to read, how to write and count.

✓ He believes that courage beats fear and that faith beats doubt.

7 Every item in a list needs its own matching word

✗ This weekend I must write an essay, do a report and a lab.

✓ This weekend I must write an essay, do a report and complete a lab.

How to check a sentence

1. Find the joining word: *and*, *or*, *but*, *nor*, *not only ... but also*, *than*, and so on.
2. Underline each item being joined.
3. Check that every item has the same form (all nouns, all *-ing*, all *to + verb*, all clauses, same tense).
4. The odd one out is the error. The correct option usually repairs it with the shortest change.

EXAM TIP

Parallelism questions often have options that are all grammatical, but only one is *balanced*. Choose the option where every item in the series looks alike.